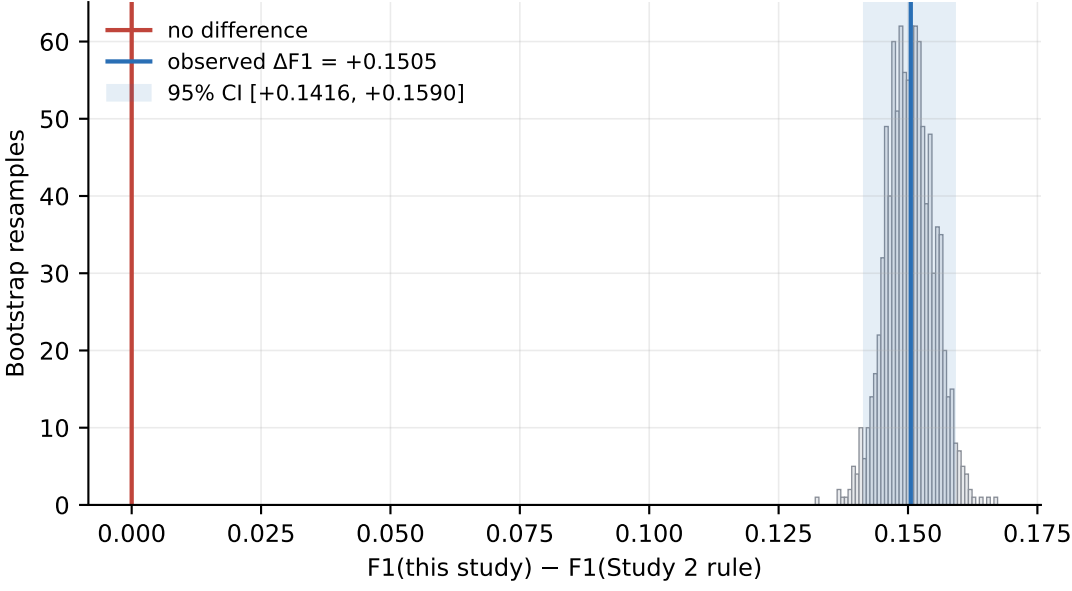
Is the headline improvement real?

Bootstrap over 4,160 field-seed units, 2,000 resamples. The interval excludes zero by a wide margin (paired permutation p = 0.0000), so the gain is not seed noise.